condition of the women and children, and pitied them,' wrote Munshi Abdul Karim.

> Out of love of God and common decency, he ordered the living to be separated from the dead, and for them to be taken to warm places and covered with sheepskins and sable pelisses. He placed them next to braziers to revive them, after the extreme cold had all but stopped the blood circulating in their veins. Such is Afghan hospitality! Even after the fiercest battle, they will succour the weak in extreme distress, as if they were their own family. For if God wills it, even a Kafir can be a cause for good.[49]

For those still on the retreat, however, the horrors continued. By the following morning, 10 January, after a second night on the exposed heights of the Khord Kabul, Hugh Johnson recorded succinctly that 'we had now not a single sepoy remaining of the whole of the Kabul Force. Every particle of our baggage was gone. We all gave ourselves up for lost . . . Every man among us thought that ere many hours should pass he was doomed to die, either by cold or hunger or butchered by our enemies . . . My eyes have become so inflamed from the reflection from the snow that I am nearly blind, and the pain is intense. Several officers are quite sightless.'[50]

Dr Brydon was lucky that morning to find the hoard of food left behind by Lady Macnaghten when she was handed over to Akbar Khan. The meat and sherry she had shared with George Lawrence were now long gone, but there were still 'some eggs and a bottle of wine . . . The eggs were not boiled but frozen quite hard, and the wine also, to the consistency of honey?. . .' It was as well for Brydon that he had some sustenance, for there followed the worst day of the retreat yet, as the snow-blinded and frostbitten troops stumbled through the narrows of the Tezin Pass where a second meticulously laid ambush awaited them. 'This was a terrible march,' Brydon recorded in his diary that night,

> the fire of the enemy incessant, and great numbers of officers and men, not knowing where they were going from snow-blindness, were cut up. I led Mr Banness, the Greek merchant, a great part of the way over the high ground, and often felt so blind myself that from time to time I applied a handful of snow to my eyes, and recommended others to do so, as it gave great relief. Descending towards Tezin, the whiteness was not so intense, and as the sun got low, the blindness went off; but the fire of the enemy increased, and as they were able to get very close to us in the Pass, which we now again entered, it was very destructive.
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> The enemy all the way pressed hard on our flanks and rear, and, on arriving at the valley of Tezin towards evening, a mere handful remained of the native regiments which had left Cabul . .